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TATHYA EARTH, NAVI MUMBAI

Founded 2019

Founders Gunjan Thakuria (in pic above), Naresh Palaiya, Himangshu Das, Nikit Shrungarpawar

Employees Nine

Product Deep learning algorithms based on remote sensing technology to identify important trends in the global economy

Funding It raised an undisclosed amount through a seed funding round held in February 2020

our knowledge and facilities for use by start-ups. Secondly, as space is a regulated environment, we have that system coming in through the establishment of IN-SPACe, the regulatory body under the Department of Space (DOS). So, once these two come together, then there is a framework on which they can operate,” says Somanath.

It is also proposed that ISRO’s commercial arm, NewSpace India Limited (NSIL), will function as the aggregator of user requirements and obtain commitments. The PSU, which is under the administrative control of the DOS, will take ownership of operational launch vehicles, commercial launches, satellites and services.

“We are putting in place all the mechanisms by which IN-SPACe will facilitate—through

ISRO or sometimes through NSIL—launch services and technology transfer to start-ups or anyone in the private sector. We will also facilitate the transfer of technology that ISRO has on a shared or exclusive basis. The way towards creating a level playing field is by giving access to young companies to technologies and infrastructure developed over decades,” says Pawan Goenka, Chairperson, IN-SPACe. The former managing director of Mahindra & Mahindra—one of the country’s largest auto-makers—was specially handpicked to enhance private participation.

Globally, the commercial space sector is worth \$360 billion. At \$7 billion, India’s share of the global business currently works out to around 2 per cent. By boosting private participation in the commercial space sector, the country hopes to substantially increase it to \$50 billion or 10 per cent by the decade’s end.

FUNDRAISING CHALLENGE

Start-ups also need investments to sustain their business model. More so in a technology-intensive area such as space exploration.

Although funding clocked a whopping 200 per cent growth in 2021 in year-on-year comparison, more will be needed. A total of \$67.2 million was raised across 11 rounds, up from \$22.5 million in 2020 across nine rounds, according to data from Tracxn, which identifies innovative start-ups from across the world for potential investors.

Goenka feels that a lot more investment from both domestic and foreign investors will start coming with the growth in the number of successfully tested products: “For that to happen, frankly, we need more success stories. At the moment we only have a few. Within the next six months, several more companies will be able to claim demonstrable successes. And once that happens, a significant amount of investment will also come in.”

Also, with the lone exception of Agnikul’s Moin, all the other co-founders interviewed for this story are first-generation entrepreneurs. The former Qantas employee, whose father manages a leather business, also tried his hand at cosmetics manufacturing after quitting his airline job before finally joining hands with Srinath. “For me, it’s been a journey from selling air fresheners to aerospace,” remarks the aeronautical engineering graduate from Anna

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